I Woke Up as the Villain Stepmom

Characters:

- **Vivian Ashford** (27): the villain stepmom, now with a new kind soul inside. Long dark wavy hair, blush satin gown.
- **Julian Ashford** (32): cold billionaire husband. Dark suit, white open-collar shirt.
- **Theo** (7): protective stepson in a navy sweater. **Rosie** (5): timid stepdaughter, bob haircut, red velvet dress with a white collar.
- **Margot** (28): fake best friend. Blonde, dusty-pink dress.
- **Damon** (30): Vivian's ex, who wants her back.
- **Mrs. Sinclair** (45): wealthy gala hostess, wine-red gown. **Oliver Sinclair** (8): her spoiled son, grey suit and bow tie, eating chocolate truffles.

Clip 1: Wrong Body

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — DAY. Extreme close-up: a manicured hand raised high, frozen mid-slap.]
[Whip pan: Theo throws himself in front of Rosie, arms wide.]
THEO: Don't hit her! Hit me instead!
[Snap zoom on Vivian's eyes, blinking in confusion. Her raised hand trembles.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought, lips not moving): Wait. Two seconds ago I was in bed, watching a drama on my phone. Where am I?
[Close-up: Rosie, tears streaming, clutching something in her fist.]
ROSIE: Please, Mommy... don't be mad.
[Slow push in on Vivian, horror dawning.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): Theo and Rosie? The twins from the show? Then I'm... Vivian. The villain stepmom who hits the kids, cheats with her ex, and gets thrown out in episode three.
[Slow motion: she lowers her hand. Freeze frame. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 2: What's in Her Hand?

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — CONTINUOUS. Whip pan: a blonde woman in a dusty-pink dress slides an arm around Vivian's shoulders.]
MARGOT: Viv, what are you doing? Why'd you stop?
VIVIAN: (cautiously) And you are...?
MARGOT: (laughing) Margot? Your best friend since college? Your stepkids are right there. Did you hit your head?
[Close-up: Vivian forces a smile.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): Margot. In the drama, she's the fake best friend who pushes

Vivian off every cliff.
[Over-the-shoulder: Margot leans in to whisper in Vivian's ear.]
MARGOT: Don't go soft now. Kids only respect fear. Make her give it back.
VIVIAN: Give what back?
MARGOT: (rolling her eyes) The bracelet she stole from your jewelry box. The one you promised me.
[Macro shot: blood drips between Rosie's small clenched fingers.]
[Snap zoom on Vivian.]
VIVIAN: Rosie... is your hand bleeding?
[Rosie hides her fist behind her back and shakes her head.]
ROSIE: No... I didn't take anything bad. I promise.

Clip 3: The Gift

[Vivian kneels slowly to Rosie's eye level.]
VIVIAN: (softly) It's okay. Open your hand for me.
[Top-down shot: Rosie's palm slowly opens. A silver bracelet with two tiny charms, a heart and a star, its clasp cutting into her skin.]
VIVIAN: Why were you hiding this, sweetheart?
ROSIE: (sobbing) Because you were going to give it to Aunt Margot...
VIVIAN: Is it... special?
[Close-up: Theo steps forward, arms crossed, angry.]
THEO: We bought it for your birthday. Rosie and I saved our allowance for six months.
ROSIE: I picked the heart. Theo picked the star. Daddy said it matched your eyes. I just wanted to ask if you could keep this one...
[Snap zoom on Vivian's face. A tear falls.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): In the drama, Vivian gave this bracelet to Margot. Rosie cried the whole episode.

Clip 4: Gentle Hands

[Close-up: Vivian snaps open a first-aid kit.]
MARGOT: (scoffing) What are you doing? It's a tiny scratch. It'll heal on its own.
[Whip pan: Vivian turns, eyes cold.]
VIVIAN: Then let me scratch your hand, and we'll see how fast yours heals.
[Close-up: Margot's smile freezes.]
MARGOT: Viv! What's gotten into you today?
[Vivian reaches for Rosie. Rosie flinches back hard and squeezes her eyes shut.]
VIVIAN: Hey, hey. I'm not going to hit you. Give me your hand.
[Rosie slowly holds out her palm, trembling.]
ROSIE: (whispering) Sorry I moved... I won't move again. Please don't be mad.

VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): I remember this scene. In the drama, Vivian slapped her just for pulling her hand away.
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): Not this time.
[Macro shot: cotton gently dabs the cut.]
VIVIAN: If it stings, squeeze my finger. I'll go really slow, okay?
ROSIE: (tiny nod) ...Okay.

Clip 5: Daddy's Home

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — CONTINUOUS. Close-up: Vivian presses a small bandage onto Rosie's palm.]
[The double doors burst open. Low angle: a tall man in a dark suit strides in, cold eyes locked on Vivian.]
JULIAN: Vivian. What are you doing to my daughter?
ROSIE: (brightening) Daddy!
[Snap zoom on Vivian, looking up at him.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): Daddy... so this is Julian Ashford. The husband.
[Close-up: Theo points straight at Vivian.]
THEO: Dad, she raised her hand at Rosie! She was going to hit her!
[Push in on Vivian, face draining of color.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): In the drama, this exact moment is when he files for divorce.
[Julian kneels to Rosie, eyes locked on her bandaged hand.]
JULIAN: Rosie. Did she hit you?
ROSIE: Not yet... The bracelet poked me. Mommy cleaned it and put a bandage on.
[Slow push in: Julian looks up at Vivian, suspicious.]
JULIAN: You? Bandaged her?
[Freeze frame on Vivian's face. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 6: Thirty Days

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — CONTINUOUS. Vivian kneels beside Theo and Rosie.]
VIVIAN: Theo, Rosie, I'm sorry. I won't ever raise my hand at either of you again.
[Close-up: Theo, arms crossed, eyes wet.]
THEO: You said that last time too.
[Snap zoom on Vivian.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): Last time? So the real Vivian did this again and again.
[She stands and faces Julian.]
VIVIAN: Julian, I know you don't believe me. So don't trust my words. Watch what I do.
JULIAN: (cold) This is your last chance, Vivian.
VIVIAN: Give me thirty days. If the kids still fear me after that, I'll sign the divorce papers myself.

[Long beat. Push in on Julian's unreadable face.]
JULIAN: Thirty days. Not one day more. And tonight, the kids come with us to the Sinclair gala.
VIVIAN: Good. I want them there.
[Julian turns and walks out. Close-up: Margot in the background, eyes narrowing.]
[Freeze frame. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 7 & 8: The Trap

[INT. DRESSING ROOM — EVENING. Close-up: Margot shuts the door and spins on Vivian.]
MARGOT: You actually apologized to those brats? They stole from you!
VIVIAN: They got hurt. That's all that matters.
[Margot smirks and holds up her phone. Close-up on the screen: a text from DAMON: "Garden. 9 p.m. I miss you."]
MARGOT: Forget them. Tonight's the Sinclair gala, and Damon will be waiting in the garden. I arranged everything.
VIVIAN: Damon?
MARGOT: (laughing) Your Damon. Your first love? The one you married Julian to spite?
[Snap zoom on Vivian.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): Damon, her ex. I remember this episode. Julian brings the twins to the gala, Vivian sneaks off to meet Damon, and the twins get blamed for breaking the gala's prize piece. That's the night Julian stops trusting her forever.
[Close-up: Vivian sweeps a gown off its hanger.]
VIVIAN: I'm not sneaking anywhere. Tonight, I'm staying with my kids.
[Push in: Margot's smile cracks.]

Clip 9: Sweet Moments

[INT. GRAND BALLROOM — NIGHT. Crane shot down a crystal chandelier: Vivian enters on Julian's arm, the twins beside her. Heads turn.]
[A woman in a wine-red gown glides over.]
MRS. SINCLAIR: Julian, Vivian! Welcome to my gala. And you brought the twins!
JULIAN: Thank you for having us, Mrs. Sinclair.
MRS. SINCLAIR: The desserts are over there, little ones. My son Oliver's around here somewhere too.
[Dessert table. Vivian kneels beside Rosie.]
VIVIAN: Which one do you want?
ROSIE: (shy) Anything's fine.
VIVIAN: Pick your favorite. And one for your brother.
THEO: (looking away) I'm not hungry.
VIVIAN: Then pick one for me. You know what I like better than anyone.
[Long beat. Theo hesitantly points to a strawberry tart. Vivian smiles warmly. Close-up: Theo's ears turn red.]

[Close-up: Vivian wipes Rosie's sticky fingers with a napkin.]
VIVIAN: Frosting everywhere. There. All clean.

Clip 11: Blamed

[Whip pan: Vivian spins away from Margot toward the crash. Snap zoom on her face.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): I looked away for two seconds. This is the scene from the drama... but this time, I'm not in the garden.
[Wide shot: guests turn. A woman in a wine-red gown pushes through the crowd.]
MRS. SINCLAIR: Oliver! What happened?!
OLIVER: (pointing) I told her not to touch it, Mom, but she wouldn't listen!
[Close-up: Rosie, crouched over the shards, trembling.]
ROSIE: (crying) It wasn't me...
THEO: He's lying! He dropped it himself!
MRS. SINCLAIR: If she didn't break it, why is she crouching over the pieces?
THEO: Because she got scared! She thought she could pick them up and fix it!
[Wide shot: whispers ripple through the crowd. Julian pushes through.]
JULIAN: Theo. Tell me exactly what happened.

Clip 12: We're Not Apologizing

[Close-up: Margot grips Vivian's wrist at the edge of the crowd.]
MARGOT: (hissing) Julian's handling it. Leave it. Damon is waiting!
VIVIAN: (pulling free) Let go of me, Margot.
[Close-up: Mrs. Sinclair, cold smile.]
MRS. SINCLAIR: That swan cost a fortune, but it's not as if my family cares about money. They're just children. An apology will do.
JULIAN: (tight jaw) I'll pay for the damages.
THEO: (shouting) But we didn't do it!
[Whip pan: Vivian steps between them.]
VIVIAN: We're not paying. And nobody is apologizing.
[The crowd gasps. Margot hisses in her ear.]
MARGOT: Viv, stop! Don't embarrass Julian in front of everyone!
VIVIAN: If we leave now, everyone here will believe my kids broke it and then lied about it.
[Low angle: Julian stares at Vivian, stunned.]
JULIAN: Vivian... what are you doing?
VIVIAN: Something I should've done a long time ago. Believing them

Clip 13: Chocolate Fingerprints

[Vivian kneels to Rosie's eye level.]
VIVIAN: Rosie. Where were your hands when it fell?

ROSIE: Behind my back. You told us not to touch anything.
OLIVER: Liar! She grabbed it from me!
[Snap zoom on Vivian.]
VIVIAN: From you? A minute ago, you said she touched it after you warned her. Which is it, Oliver?
MRS. SINCLAIR: He's just confused. He didn't explain it clearly—
[Vivian picks up a shard. Macro shot: dark brown chocolate smudges on the crystal.]
VIVIAN: Chocolate fingerprints. My daughter only ate a strawberry tart. And look at her hand.
[Close-up: Vivian gently lifts Rosie's hand. A spotless white bandage, not a single smudge.]
[Slow motion: Vivian turns Oliver's palm up. Close-up: smeared chocolate.]
VIVIAN: So whose hands are dirty now?
[Wide shot: the crowd erupts in whispers. Mrs. Sinclair goes pale.]
[Freeze frame. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 14: Mommy Believed Me

[Close-up: Mrs. Sinclair, jaw tight, staring at the chocolate on her son's palm.]
MRS. SINCLAIR: (through gritted teeth) Oliver. Apologize. Now.
OLIVER: (mumbling, eyes on the floor) ...Sorry, Rosie.
[Whip pan: Rosie throws her arms around Vivian's neck.]
ROSIE: Mommy believed me!
[Close-up: Theo hesitates, then quietly slips his small hand into Vivian's.]
THEO: (barely a whisper) ...Thanks.
[Snap zoom on Vivian, eyes glistening.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): In the drama, Rosie cried alone in the car tonight. Not anymore.
[Push in on Julian, staring at his wife like a stranger.]
JULIAN (V.O., inner thought): Who are you? And what happened to my wife?
[Whip pan to the garden doors: a handsome man in a navy suit strides in, eyes locked on Vivian.]
DAMON: (loudly) Vivian! I waited an hour in that garden!
[Freeze frame on Julian's face turning to stone. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 15: The Ex

[Wide shot: the crowd falls silent. Damon stops in front of Vivian.]
DAMON: You told me to come tonight. Why didn't you show up?
VIVIAN: (cold) I don't know what you're talking about.
[Close-up: Julian steps forward, voice like ice.]
JULIAN: And who are you?
DAMON: (smirking) Damon. Ask your wife. She's been texting me for weeks.
[Damon holds up his phone. Macro shot: a chat labeled "VIVIAN 💋": "Garden. 9 p.m. I miss you."]
[Snap zoom on Vivian.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): This never happened in the drama. In the drama, Vivian went to him. So who sent these?

[Close-up: Margot in the background, lips pressed tight, clutching her purse.]
JULIAN: (low, dangerous) Vivian. Explain.

Clip 16: The Other Phone

[Vivian holds Julian's gaze, steady.]
VIVIAN: I never sent those. And I can prove it.
[She turns to Damon.]
VIVIAN: Call that number. Right now. In front of everyone.
DAMON: (hesitating) ...Fine.
[Close-up: Damon taps "Call." Long beat.]
[Snap zoom: a phone buzzes loudly inside Margot's pink clutch.]
[Close-up: Rosie points.]
ROSIE: Aunt Margot, your bag is ringing!
[Whip pan: every head turns. Margot clutches the purse to her chest.]
MARGOT: (panicked laugh) It's... just a coincidence!
[Julian pulls the purse from her hands. Macro shot: a second phone, its screen glowing "DAMON CALLING."]
JULIAN: Why does my wife's best friend have a phone pretending to be my wife?
[Freeze frame on Margot's face draining of color. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 17: The Real Motive

[Close-up: Margot's trembling hands. Then her face hardens.]
MARGOT: (snapping) Fine! Yes, I sent them!
[Wide shot: the crowd gasps.]
VIVIAN: Why, Margot? I thought you were my best friend.
MARGOT: Your best friend? I've stood behind you for ten years, watching you waste everything you had!
[Whip pan: Margot turns to Julian, eyes wet.]
MARGOT: You were supposed to find her in that garden with him tonight. Then you'd finally see who she really is.
[Close-up: Damon steps back, stunned.]
DAMON: You told me she still loved me. You used me?
[Snap zoom on Vivian.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): Now I remember. In the drama, after the divorce, Julian married Margot. This was her plan all along.
[Push in on Julian, cold fury in his eyes.]
JULIAN: You wanted to destroy my family... to take her place?

Clip 18: Get Out

[Close-up: Julian signals with two fingers. Two security guards step forward.]
JULIAN: Escort Miss Margot out. She's no longer welcome near my family.
[Guards take Margot's arms. She twists back toward Vivian.]
MARGOT: (hissing) You think you've won? I know every secret you've ever told me, Vivian. Every single one.
[Snap zoom on Vivian.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): The real Vivian's secrets... and I don't know any of them.
[Margot is dragged through the crowd as phones film her.]
[Close-up: Damon reaches for Vivian's hand. She pulls it away.]
DAMON: Viv, wait. Whatever she did, what we had was real.
VIVIAN: Whatever the old Vivian felt for you is gone. Don't contact me again.
DAMON: (smirking as he backs away) We'll see.
[Low angle: Julian watches Damon leave, then looks at Vivian.]

Clip 19: Day One

[INT. LUXURY CAR — NIGHT. City lights stream past the windows. Rosie sleeps on Vivian's lap. Theo leans heavily against her shoulder.]
JULIAN: You defended them. Then you defended yourself. You've never done either.
VIVIAN: (softly) Let's just say I finally woke up.
[Close-up: Julian studies her, unreadable.]
JULIAN: Day one of thirty, Vivian.
VIVIAN: Then I'll make the other twenty-nine count.
[Close-up: Theo, half asleep, murmurs against her arm.]
THEO: (sleepy whisper) Goodnight... Mom.
[Snap zoom on Vivian, a tear rolling down her cheek.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): He's never called her Mom. Not once in the whole drama.
[Close-up: Vivian's phone buzzes in her clutch. Macro shot: a text from UNKNOWN NUMBER: "I know you're not the real Vivian."]
[Freeze frame on Vivian's horrified face. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 20: Let Me Make It Up to You

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — ENTRYWAY — DAY. Whip pan: Margot sweeps in, smoothing her dress, flashing a bright smile.]

MARGOT: I know I messed up, Viv. Let me make it up to you — a whole day, just us and the kids. Shopping, lunch, whatever you want. My treat. Well, your treat, but you know what I mean. Just let me prove to you that I can actually change for once.

[Close-up: Vivian's arms cross, studying her carefully.]

VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): The old Vivian would've forgiven her in a heartbeat. I'm not her.

VIVIAN: Fine. For the kids. Not for you.

[Snap zoom on Margot's smile, something calculating behind it. Freeze frame. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

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[Snap zoom on Vivian's eyes, blinking in confusion. Her raised hand trembles.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought, lips not moving): Wait. Two seconds ago I was in bed, watching a drama on my phone. Where am I?
[Close-up: Rosie, tears streaming, clutching something in her fist.]
ROSIE: Please, Mommy... don't be mad.
[Slow push in on Vivian, horror dawning.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): Theo and Rosie? The twins from the show? Then I'm... Vivian. The villain stepmom who hits the kids, cheats with her ex, and gets thrown out in episode three.
[Slow motion: she lowers her hand. Freeze frame. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 2: What's in Her Hand?

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — CONTINUOUS. Whip pan: a blonde woman in a dusty-pink dress slides an arm around Vivian's shoulders.]
MARGOT: Viv, what are you doing? Why'd you stop?
VIVIAN: (cautiously) And you are...?
MARGOT: (laughing) Margot? Your best friend since college? Your stepkids are right there. Did you hit your head?
[Close-up: Vivian forces a smile.]
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[Over-the-shoulder: Margot leans in to whisper in Vivian's ear.]
MARGOT: Don't go soft now. Kids only respect fear. Make her give it back.
VIVIAN: Give what back?
MARGOT: (rolling her eyes) The bracelet she stole from your jewelry box. The one you promised me.
[Macro shot: blood drips between Rosie's small clenched fingers.]
[Snap zoom on Vivian.]
VIVIAN: Rosie... is your hand bleeding?
[Rosie hides her fist behind her back and shakes her head.]
ROSIE: No... I didn't take anything bad. I promise.

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[Vivian kneels slowly to Rosie's eye level.]
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[Top-down shot: Rosie's palm slowly opens. A silver bracelet with two tiny charms, a heart and a star, its clasp cutting into her skin.]
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[Whip pan: Vivian turns, eyes cold.]
VIVIAN: Then let me scratch your hand, and we'll see how fast yours heals.
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MARGOT: Viv! What's gotten into you today?
[Vivian reaches for Rosie. Rosie flinches back hard and squeezes her eyes shut.]
VIVIAN: Hey, hey. I'm not going to hit you. Give me your hand.
[Rosie slowly holds out her palm, trembling.]
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[Julian turns and walks out. Close-up: Margot in the background, eyes narrowing.]
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MRS. SINCLAIR: That swan cost a fortune, but it's not as if my family cares about money. They're just children. An apology will do.
JULIAN: (tight jaw) I'll pay for the damages.
THEO: (shouting) But we didn't do it!
[Whip pan: Vivian steps between them.]
VIVIAN: We're not paying. And nobody is apologizing.
[The crowd gasps. Margot hisses in her ear.]
MARGOT: Viv, stop! Don't embarrass Julian in front of everyone!
VIVIAN: If we leave now, everyone here will believe my kids broke it and then lied about it.
[Low angle: Julian stares at Vivian, stunned.]

JULIAN: Vivian... what are you doing?
VIVIAN: Something I should've done a long time ago. Believing them

Clip 13: Chocolate Fingerprints

[Vivian kneels to Rosie's eye level.]
VIVIAN: Rosie. Where were your hands when it fell?
ROSIE: Behind my back. You told us not to touch anything.
OLIVER: Liar! She grabbed it from me!
[Snap zoom on Vivian.]
VIVIAN: From you? A minute ago, you said she touched it after you warned her. Which is it, Oliver?
MRS. SINCLAIR: He's just confused. He didn't explain it clearly—
[Vivian picks up a shard. Macro shot: dark brown chocolate smudges on the crystal.]
VIVIAN: Chocolate fingerprints. My daughter only ate a strawberry tart. And look at her hand.
[Close-up: Vivian gently lifts Rosie's hand. A spotless white bandage, not a single smudge.]
[Slow motion: Vivian turns Oliver's palm up. Close-up: smeared chocolate.]
VIVIAN: So whose hands are dirty now?
[Wide shot: the crowd erupts in whispers. Mrs. Sinclair goes pale.]
[Freeze frame. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 14: Mommy Believed Me

[Close-up: Mrs. Sinclair, jaw tight, staring at the chocolate on her son's palm.]
MRS. SINCLAIR: (through gritted teeth) Oliver. Apologize. Now.
OLIVER: (mumbling, eyes on the floor) ...Sorry, Rosie.
[Whip pan: Rosie throws her arms around Vivian's neck.]
ROSIE: Mommy believed me!
[Close-up: Theo hesitates, then quietly slips his small hand into Vivian's.]
THEO: (barely a whisper) ...Thanks.
[Snap zoom on Vivian, eyes glistening.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): In the drama, Rosie cried alone in the car tonight. Not anymore.
[Push in on Julian, staring at his wife like a stranger.]
JULIAN (V.O., inner thought): Who are you? And what happened to my wife?
[Whip pan to the garden doors: a handsome man in a navy suit strides in, eyes locked on Vivian.]
DAMON: (loudly) Vivian! I waited an hour in that garden!
[Freeze frame on Julian's face turning to stone. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 15: The Ex

[Wide shot: the crowd falls silent. Damon stops in front of Vivian.]
DAMON: You told me to come tonight. Why didn't you show up?

VIVIAN: (cold) I don't know what you're talking about.
[Close-up: Julian steps forward, voice like ice.]
JULIAN: And who are you?
DAMON: (smirking) Damon. Ask your wife. She's been texting me for weeks.
[Damon holds up his phone. Macro shot: a chat labeled "VIVIAN 💋": "Garden. 9 p.m. I miss you."]
[Snap zoom on Vivian.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): This never happened in the drama. In the drama, Vivian went to him. So who sent these?
[Close-up: Margot in the background, lips pressed tight, clutching her purse.]
JULIAN: (low, dangerous) Vivian. Explain.

Clip 16: The Other Phone

[Vivian holds Julian's gaze, steady.]
VIVIAN: I never sent those. And I can prove it.
[She turns to Damon.]
VIVIAN: Call that number. Right now. In front of everyone.
DAMON: (hesitating) ...Fine.
[Close-up: Damon taps "Call." Long beat.]
[Snap zoom: a phone buzzes loudly inside Margot's pink clutch.]
[Close-up: Rosie points.]
ROSIE: Aunt Margot, your bag is ringing!
[Whip pan: every head turns. Margot clutches the purse to her chest.]
MARGOT: (panicked laugh) It's... just a coincidence!
[Julian pulls the purse from her hands. Macro shot: a second phone, its screen glowing "DAMON CALLING."]
JULIAN: Why does my wife's best friend have a phone pretending to be my wife?
[Freeze frame on Margot's face draining of color. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 17: The Real Motive

[Close-up: Margot's trembling hands. Then her face hardens.]
MARGOT: (snapping) Fine! Yes, I sent them!
[Wide shot: the crowd gasps.]
VIVIAN: Why, Margot? I thought you were my best friend.
MARGOT: Your best friend? I've stood behind you for ten years, watching you waste everything you had!
[Whip pan: Margot turns to Julian, eyes wet.]
MARGOT: You were supposed to find her in that garden with him tonight. Then you'd finally see who she really is.

[Close-up: Damon steps back, stunned.]
DAMON: You told me she still loved me. You used me?
[Snap zoom on Vivian.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): Now I remember. In the drama, after the divorce, Julian married Margot. This was her plan all along.
[Push in on Julian, cold fury in his eyes.]
JULIAN: You wanted to destroy my family... to take her place?

Clip 18: Get Out

[Close-up: Julian signals with two fingers. Two security guards step forward.]
JULIAN: Escort Miss Margot out. She's no longer welcome near my family.
[Guards take Margot's arms. She twists back toward Vivian.]
MARGOT: (hissing) You think you've won? I know every secret you've ever told me, Vivian. Every single one.
[Snap zoom on Vivian.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): The real Vivian's secrets... and I don't know any of them.
[Margot is dragged through the crowd as phones film her.]
[Close-up: Damon reaches for Vivian's hand. She pulls it away.]
DAMON: Viv, wait. Whatever she did, what we had was real.
VIVIAN: Whatever the old Vivian felt for you is gone. Don't contact me again.
DAMON: (smirking as he backs away) We'll see.
[Low angle: Julian watches Damon leave, then looks at Vivian.]

Clip 19: Day One

[INT. LUXURY CAR — NIGHT. City lights stream past the windows. Rosie sleeps on Vivian's lap. Theo leans heavily against her shoulder.]
JULIAN: You defended them. Then you defended yourself. You've never done either.
VIVIAN: (softly) Let's just say I finally woke up.
[Close-up: Julian studies her, unreadable.]
JULIAN: Day one of thirty, Vivian.
VIVIAN: Then I'll make the other twenty-nine count.
[Close-up: Theo, half asleep, murmurs against her arm.]
THEO: (sleepy whisper) Goodnight... Mom.
[Snap zoom on Vivian, a tear rolling down her cheek.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): He's never called her Mom. Not once in the whole drama.
[Close-up: Vivian's phone buzzes in her clutch. Macro shot: a text from UNKNOWN NUMBER: "I know you're not the real Vivian."]
[Freeze frame on Vivian's horrified face. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 20: The Bill

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — BREAKFAST ROOM — MORNING. Sunlight. Rosie and Theo eat pancakes. Vivian's phone lies face-up on the table, showing the unknown text: "I know you're not the real Vivian."]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): No name. No number I recognize. Who else knows?
[Close-up: Julian drops a thick folder beside her plate.]
JULIAN: My accountant went through your accounts last night, after what Margot did.
VIVIAN: (opening it) And?
JULIAN: Three years of her shopping. On your cards.
[Macro shot: pages of charges highlighted in yellow. Snap zoom on one line: "CUSTOM PENDANT — BALANCE DUE — PICKUP TODAY."]
VIVIAN: She ordered something in my name... and she's picking it up today?
JULIAN: The boutique called to confirm.
[Close-up: Vivian closes the folder, eyes cold.]
VIVIAN: Then I'll be there to meet her.
ROSIE: Can we come too?
THEO: (cautious) You never take us anywhere.
VIVIAN: (smiling) Then today's the first time.

Clip 21: The Letter M

[INT. LUXURY BOUTIQUE — DAY. Marble floors, glass display cases. Margot stands at the counter in a glittering new gown, sunglasses on her head.]
MARGOT: (to the manager) The Ashford order. I'm collecting it for Vivian.
[Whip pan: the doors open. Vivian walks in holding Rosie's and Theo's hands.]
VIVIAN: Collecting what for me, Margot?
[Snap zoom: Margot's smile freezes.]
[The manager opens a velvet box. Macro shot: a diamond pendant shaped like a sparkling letter "M."]
ROSIE: (pointing) That's not Mommy's letter. That's Aunt Margot's!
MARGOT: (quickly) It's a gift for you, Viv! I designed it myself!
MANAGER: Ms. Margot asked for the "M" specifically, ma'am. The remaining balance is two hundred thousand dollars.
[Close-up: Vivian slides the box back across the counter toward Margot.]
VIVIAN: Then congratulations on your gift. You're paying for it.
[Close-up: the manager runs Margot's card. Macro shot on the screen: DECLINED.]
MARGOT: (panicking) Viv... please. Not in front of everyone.

Clip 22 & 23 - Combined: Partners

[Close-up: Vivian holds out her open palm.]
VIVIAN: Car keys. The car's in my name.
MARGOT: You said I could use it forever!
VIVIAN: And now I'm taking it back. Along with every dress, bag and piece of jewelry you "borrowed." By tomorrow.
MARGOT: (hissing) You'll regret this, Vivian.
[Close-up: Theo looks up at Vivian, thoughtful.]
THEO: Is that why Aunt Margot always had new things? Because they were yours?
VIVIAN: (softly) Not anymore.
[EXT. BOUTIQUE PARKING GARAGE — DAY. Margot storms out and climbs into a black sports car. Reveal: Damon is behind the wheel.]
DAMON: Well? Where's the necklace?
MARGOT: She made me pay for it. She took the car.
DAMON: (smirking, holding up his phone) Relax. I already sent her a little message.
[Macro shot: Damon's screen, the same text: "I know you're not the real Vivian."]
DAMON: Let's see how long she keeps acting brave.
[Freeze frame on Margot's slow, wicked smile. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 24: Day Two

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — WALK-IN DRESSING ROOM — NIGHT. Soft amber lights. Racks of silk nightwear. Vivian, hair loose, holds up a buttoned-up cotton nightgown.] VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought, lips not moving): My name is Emma. I teach kindergarten. I eat instant noodles for dinner. And now I'm a billionaire's wife. [Close-up: she tosses the nightgown aside and lifts a tiny black lace slip. Her eyes widen.] VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): Absolutely not. [Whip pan: she pulls out a long wine-red satin nightgown. Slow push in as she holds it against herself in the mirror.] VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): Married to a man who looks like that... and the real Vivian made him sleep down the hall? [INT. HALLWAY — NIGHT. Vivian in wine-red satin and a matching silk robe, barefoot, outside a tall dark door. Her hand hovers.] VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): It's only day two. I need him to trust me. That's the only reason I'm doing this. [Close-up: she sprays perfume on her wrist and knocks twice.] JULIAN (O.S.): (low) Come in.

Clip 25: Rules Change

[INT. JULIAN'S BEDROOM — NIGHT. Moonlight through floor-to-ceiling windows. Julian, in dark silk pajamas, reads contracts. He looks up, and freezes.] JULIAN: It's midnight, Vivian. VIVIAN: (leaning against the door) Is there a rule against visiting my own husband? JULIAN: Separate rooms were *your* rule. From our wedding night. VIVIAN: (slowly walking toward the window) Rules change. So do I. [Julian sets the papers down and rises. Slow tracking shot as he crosses toward her.] JULIAN: You walked in here dressed like that. What exactly are you testing? VIVIAN: (holding his gaze) Whether my husband is really as cold as he pretends. [Low

angle: he steps closer. Her back meets the cool glass. His fingertips trace her jaw.] JULIAN: (quietly) Careful. I'm not the one who runs away. [Extreme close-up: their lips inches apart. Her breath catches.] [Snap cut: three small knocks at the door.]

Clip 26: The Earring

[Whip pan: the door creaks open. Rosie in pajamas, hugging a stuffed penguin and holding a folded paper.] ROSIE: Daddy? ...Why is Mommy in your room? [Vivian jumps away from Julian, tucking her hair behind her ear.] VIVIAN: I... lost an earring! JULIAN: (slow smirk) We were looking for it. Very closely. ROSIE: Did you find it? VIVIAN: (flustered) ...Not yet. JULIAN: (under his breath) We'll keep looking. [Macro shot: a school flyer with a cartoon penguin: "FAMILY PLAY NIGHT — FRIDAY."] ROSIE: I'm the baby penguin who gets lost on the ice! At the end, the mommy penguin finds me and takes me home. ROSIE: (hopeful but nervous) Will you be my mommy penguin? ...It's okay if you're busy. VIVIAN: (softening) I would love to.

Clip 27 & 28 - COMBINED: The Last Line

[The door opens again. Theo, frowning.] THEO: Why is everyone in Dad's room? ROSIE: Mommy's going to be my mommy penguin! THEO: (arms crossed) Last year you promised to come to her recital. She sat on the stage steps until they turned off the lights. VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): The real Vivian did that to her? [Vivian kneels to their level.] VIVIAN: This time I'll be there. Front row. I promise. THEO: And if you forget? VIVIAN: Then you remind me. You're my favorite reminder. THEO: (hiding a tiny smile) ...I'm the narrator. I'll be watching. ROSIE: (tugging Julian's sleeve) We still need a daddy penguin! And at the end, the daddy penguin kisses the mommy penguin! [Snap zoom on Vivian, frozen. Julian looks at her, eyes dark and amused.] JULIAN: Then I suppose we'll need to rehearse. [Freeze frame on Vivian's blushing face. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 29: Penguin Practice

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — LIVING ROOM — DAY 3, AFTERNOON. Sofa cushions pushed aside to make a “stage.” Vivian wears a fluffy black-and-white mommy-penguin cape. Rosie waddles in a baby-penguin costume. Theo holds a crumpled script.]
THEO: (narrating) The baby penguin slid across the ice, looking everywhere for her mommy...
[Close-up: Rosie waddles in a circle, hand shading her eyes.]
ROSIE: Mommy? Where are you?
[Whip pan: Vivian sweeps in, arms wide.]
VIVIAN: Baby penguin! Mommy’s here to take you home!
[Rosie stops and puts her hands on her hips.]
ROSIE: No, no! You have to hug me first. Then you say it.
VIVIAN: Is that in the script?

[Close-up: Theo flips the page. Macro shot: a line scribbled in purple crayon.]
THEO: It is now. She wrote it in crayon.
[Vivian laughs and scoops Rosie into a tight hug. Close-up: Rosie snuggles in, eyes closed.]
ROSIE: (muffled) Your hugs are warmer now.
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought, lips not moving): Warmer than what? ...The real Vivian never hugged her at all.

Clip 30: Family Plans

[The front door opens. Julian walks in, loosening his tie, and stops at the sight of the penguins.]
ROSIE: Daddy penguin! Perfect timing!
[Close-up: Rosie holds up a fuzzy penguin hat with a floppy orange beak.]
JULIAN: I agreed to drive you to the play. Not to wear that.
VIVIAN: (teasing) The CEO of Ashford Group... scared of a penguin hat?
[Long beat. Julian takes the hat and pulls it on. Close-up: the beak flops over his nose. Theo snorts.]
JULIAN: (deadpan) One run-through.
[His phone buzzes. Close-up on the screen: ASSISTANT.]
ASSISTANT (V.O., phone): Sir, the board confirmed Friday, seven p.m. The overseas investors are flying in.
[Close-up: Rosie's smile fades.]
ROSIE: (small voice) That's play night...
[Julian looks at Rosie, then speaks into the phone.]
JULIAN: Push it to Monday. Tell the board my daughter outranks them.
[He hangs up. Rosie gasps.]
ROSIE: You're really coming?
JULIAN: (kneeling, beak still flopping) A daddy penguin never misses the ice.

Clip 31 & 32 – COMBINED: Rehearsal

[Theo stands on the coffee table, reading dramatically.]
THEO: And the daddy penguin found them both, and they waddled home together.
JULIAN: (stiff, in the penguin hat) Found you. Let's go home.
ROSIE: With feeling, Daddy!
[Close-up: Theo turns the page and grins.]
THEO: And the last part... the daddy penguin kisses the mommy penguin.
[Rosie giggles. The twins grab hands and race upstairs.]
ROSIE: (calling back) Goodnight! Practice without us!
[Snap zoom on Vivian, flustered, fiddling with her cape.]
VIVIAN: We'll just... skip that part on Friday.
[Julian pulls off the penguin hat and steps closer. He fixes the collar of her cape.]

JULIAN: The teacher already has the script.
VIVIAN: (breathless) Then we'll improvise.
JULIAN: (quietly) I don't improvise, Vivian. I rehearse.
[Slow push in: he kisses her, slowly. Her hands grip his shirt.]
[Whip pan up the staircase: Theo and Rosie peeking through the railing. They silently high-five.]
[Freeze frame. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 33: Parking Lot

[EXT. MAPLEWOOD ELEMENTARY — PARKING LOT — DAY 5, DUSK. Orange sky. Parents in coats stream toward the glowing school doors. Vivian hurries from her car, a garment bag over her arm with the fluffy penguin cape spilling out.]
[Close-up: her phone screen: 5:52 PM. A text from Theo: "Front row. You promised."]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought, lips not moving): Eight minutes. I can make it.
[Snap zoom: a figure steps out from between two parked cars. Damon, in a black leather jacket, blocks her path.]
DAMON: Big night, Mommy Penguin?
VIVIAN: (cold) Move.
DAMON: Five million. Wired tonight.
VIVIAN: Or what?
[Damon tilts his head toward the parents walking past.]
DAMON: Or I walk into that auditorium and tell every parent in there that Mrs. Ashford spent her first year of marriage sneaking off to see me.
[Push in on Vivian's face, her grip tightening on the garment bag.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): That's the real Vivian's past... and I can't even deny it.

Clip 34: The Yacht

[Damon steps closer, smug.]
DAMON: You could never stay away from me, Viv. Ever since the yacht.
[Snap zoom on Vivian's eyes, narrowing.]
VIVIAN: The yacht... where Margot pushed me overboard, and you just happened to dive in?
[Quick insert, 2 seconds, desaturated blue tint, soft blurred edges: a phone screen glowing in the dark. On screen, a yacht party at night. A blonde woman shoves a dark-haired woman over the railing, and a man in a leather jacket dives in after her.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): In the drama, that "rescue" made Vivian fall for him. They planned every second of it.
[Hard cut back to the present, full warm color. Damon's smile vanishes.]
DAMON: (low) Who told you that?
VIVIAN: Doesn't matter. You're not getting another cent.
[Damon grabs her wrist. Whip pan: Vivian slaps him hard across the face.]

DAMON: (holding his cheek) You'll regret this.
VIVIAN: Go ahead. Let's see whose story they believe.
[She pulls free and runs toward the school doors.]

Clip 35 & 36 – Combined: Lost on the Ice

[INT. SCHOOL AUDITORIUM — NIGHT. Paper icebergs and blue stage lights. In the front row, one empty seat with a handmade sign: "RESERVED — MOM." Julian waits backstage in his penguin hat.]
[At the side of the stage, Theo holds his script, eyes fixed on the empty seat.]
THEO: (narrating) The baby penguin searched and searched... but her mommy didn't come.
[Center stage: Rosie alone in her baby-penguin costume, under a single spotlight. Her lip trembles.]
ROSIE: (voice shaking) Mommy penguin... aren't you coming?
[Close-up: Theo's jaw tightens.]
THEO: (whispering) She promised...
[Whip pan: the auditorium doors burst open. Vivian runs down the aisle, cape half on, hair windswept. Heads turn.]
[She climbs onto the stage and drops to her knees in front of Rosie.]
VIVIAN: (breathless) Baby penguin! I'm here. I promised, didn't I?
[She pulls Rosie into a tight hug. Close-up: Rosie's face lights up.]
ROSIE: (whispering) You remembered. Hug first.
[Close-up: Theo exhales, smiles, and reads on.]
THEO: (narrating) And the mommy penguin found her baby... just in time.

Clip 37: Curtain Call

[INT. SCHOOL AUDITORIUM — NIGHT. Blue stage lights. Julian waddles onstage in his penguin hat, the floppy orange beak bouncing. The audience chuckles.]
THEO: (narrating) Then the daddy penguin found them both...
JULIAN: (warmly this time) Found you both. Let's go home together.
[Close-up: Rosie tugs on his flipper and whispers loudly enough for the whole room to hear.]
ROSIE: Daddy! The last part!
[The audience laughs. Snap zoom on Vivian, blushing.]
JULIAN: (quietly, just to her) You were late.
VIVIAN: (whispering) I'm here now.
[Slow push in: Julian cups her face and kisses her under the spotlight. Wide shot: the audience erupts in applause. Close-up: Theo grinning from ear to ear, script pressed to his chest.]
[Snap cut: a single phone buzzes in the front row. Then another. Then dozens at once, a ripple of notification chimes across the dark auditorium.]

[Freeze frame on a mother staring at her screen, hand over her mouth. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 38: Leaked

[Macro shot: a phone screen. An anonymous account, @TheRealAshfords, has posted a photo of Vivian kissing Damon in a parked car. Caption: “Mrs. Ashford’s perfect family? She was still seeing her ex a year after the wedding.”]
[Wide shot: the applause dies. Parents whisper and turn toward the stage.]
PARENT 1: (whispering) Isn’t that her? The stepmom up there?
PARENT 2: She was cheating on him?
[Phones rise one by one, filming the stage. Close-up: Vivian sees a screen in the front row. Her face drains of color.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought, lips not moving): That’s the real Vivian... and I don’t even know if it’s true.
[Close-up: Rosie tugs Vivian’s cape, confused.]
ROSIE: Mommy, why is everyone looking at us?
[Julian’s phone buzzes. He looks at it. His jaw locks. Slowly, he looks up at Vivian.]
[Whip pan to the back of the auditorium: Damon leans against the exit door, rubbing his cheek where she slapped him, and smirks.]
JULIAN: (low, controlled) Take the kids. We’re leaving. Now.

Clip 39: The Gate

[EXT. MAPLEWOOD ELEMENTARY — FRONT GATE — NIGHT. Camera flashes explode. A crowd of reporters surges toward the family as they rush out, the twins still in their costumes.]
REPORTER 1: Mrs. Ashford! Were you seeing your ex after the wedding?
REPORTER 2: Mr. Ashford, did you know?
[Close-up: a reporter shoves a microphone down toward Rosie.]
REPORTER 3: Sweetheart, has your stepmom ever hurt you?
[Rosie freezes and hides behind Vivian’s cape. Whip pan: Julian’s hand slams over the lens.]
JULIAN: (ice-cold) Get that camera away from my children.
REPORTER 1: Are you divorcing her?
JULIAN: This is a family matter.
[Vivian shields the twins and guides them into the car. Flashes strobe through the windows.]
[INT. CAR — NIGHT. Silence. Close-up: Theo, still holding his crumpled script, looks up at her.]
THEO: (quietly) ...Is it true?
[Snap zoom on Vivian. She opens her mouth, then closes it.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): I don’t know. I wasn’t there.
[Freeze frame on Vivian’s face. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 40: Are They Real?

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — JULIAN'S STUDY — DAY 5, NIGHT. One desk lamp. Julian sits with his laptop open. On the screen, the leaked photos of Vivian and Damon. Vivian stands in the doorway, still in her penguin cape.]
JULIAN: (without looking up) Are these real?
VIVIAN: (quietly) ...They look real.
JULIAN: When did it start?
[Snap zoom on Vivian, silent.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought, lips not moving): I don't know. I don't have her memories. How do I defend a life I never lived?
JULIAN: Before the wedding?
VIVIAN: ...Yes. Before.
[Julian finally looks up, eyes cold.]
JULIAN: And after?
VIVIAN: (struggling) I... I can't explain it.
[Close-up: Julian slowly closes the laptop.]
JULIAN: (low) That's not a no.
[Freeze frame on Vivian's face. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 41: Was It All an Act?

[Julian stands and walks to the window, his back to her.]
JULIAN: The bandage. The penguin play. Coming to my room. Was any of it real? Or was it all to make me trust you, for him?
VIVIAN: Damon blackmailed me tonight, in the parking lot. He wanted five million. I slapped him and said no.
JULIAN: (turning) And why should I believe that?
VIVIAN: You don't have to. Not tonight.
[She steps closer. Close-up: her voice breaks.]
VIVIAN: But the night I came to your room... I came because I wanted to. That part was mine.
[Long beat. Julian's jaw tightens. He walks past her to the door.]
JULIAN: Goodnight, Vivian.
[The door clicks shut. Vivian stands alone. Close-up: her fingers find the heart-and-star bracelet on her wrist.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): Day five... and I'm already losing him.

Clip 42: Pancake Peace

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — BREAKFAST ROOM — DAY 6, MORNING. Heavy silence. Julian reads his tablet. Vivian stares into her coffee. Neither looks at the other.]

[Rosie climbs onto her chair, proudly carrying two plates with lopsided heart-shaped pancakes.]
ROSIE: Heart pancakes! One for Daddy, one for Mommy.
THEO: (mouth full) She saw it in a cartoon. Hearts fix fights.
ROSIE: (looking between them) ...Are you two fighting?
[Julian and Vivian exchange a quick glance.]
JULIAN: Eat your breakfast, Rosie.
VIVIAN: (soft smile) We're just tired, sweetheart.
ROSIE: (pushing the plates closer) Then eat the hearts. All of them.
[Long beat. Julian cuts a piece and takes a bite. Close-up: the corner of his mouth twitches, almost a smile.]
[Snap cut: Theo's tablet pings. He looks down and his face falls.]
THEO: Mom... Aunt Margot is on the news.
[Freeze frame on Vivian's face. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 43: Margot's Video

[Macro shot: Theo's tablet. A video titled "MARGOT SPEAKS OUT." Margot sits under soft lighting, eyes red, tissue in hand.]
MARGOT (ON SCREEN): I've known Vivian for ten years. When I tried to protect those children, she had me thrown out.
MARGOT (ON SCREEN): (wiping tears) A week ago, she nearly slapped little Rosie over a bracelet. That poor girl begged her not to be mad.
MARGOT (ON SCREEN): Every sweet thing since then is an act, to get money out of Julian for her lover.
[INT. BREAKFAST ROOM — DAY 6, MORNING. Silence. Close-up: Julian slowly sets down his fork.]
[Close-up: Theo's hands grip the tablet. He looks up, fierce.]
THEO: That's a lie. She bandaged Rosie's hand. I was there.
[Rosie holds up her palm, a small healed scar where the bandage was.]
ROSIE: See? Mommy fixed it.
[Snap zoom on Vivian, eyes filling with tears.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought, lips not moving): Seven years old... and he's defending me.

Clip 44: Banned

[Vivian's phone rings. Close-up on the screen: MAPLEWOOD ELEMENTARY — PRINCIPAL HALE.]
PRINCIPAL HALE (V.O., phone): Mrs. Ashford, we've received dozens of complaints from parents. Until we investigate, I have to ask you not to come onto school grounds.
VIVIAN: (stunned) Not even to drop off my kids?
PRINCIPAL HALE (V.O., phone): I'm sorry.

[Click. Close-up: Rosie, worried.]
ROSIE: Then who's going to walk me to class?
[Long beat. Julian folds his napkin.]
JULIAN: I will.
[Vivian looks at him, surprised. He doesn't meet her eyes.]
[Her phone buzzes again. Macro shot: a text from an UNKNOWN NUMBER: "Price went up. $10 million. Or the next photos are worse."]
[Push in on Vivian's face hardening.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): In the drama, this is where Vivian ran back to Damon and begged. Not this time.

Clip 45: Mr. Lawson

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — FOYER — DAY. The butler opens the front door.]
BUTLER: Ma'am... your father is here.
[Low angle: a dignified grey-haired man in a camel coat steps inside, his face tired and stern.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): Mr. Lawson. The real Vivian's father.
MR. LAWSON: Damon called me last night. Ten million, or he takes everything to the press.
[Close-up: he pulls a checkbook from his coat.]
MR. LAWSON: I'll pay it. On one condition.
VIVIAN: (quietly) What condition?
MR. LAWSON: You cut that man out of your life for good. You treat your husband right. And you take care of those children.
[Snap zoom on Vivian.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): In the drama, she hated her father for keeping her away from Damon... when he was the only one trying to save her.
[Freeze frame on Mr. Lawson holding out the pen. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 46: My Mess

[Close-up: Mr. Lawson holds out the pen. Vivian looks at it, then gently pushes his hand back.]
VIVIAN: No, Dad. Put it away.
MR. LAWSON: (stunned) Vivian, this is ten million dollars. They'll ruin you.
VIVIAN: If we pay once, they'll never stop. They'll come back for more every month.
[She steps closer, steady.]
VIVIAN: This is my mess. I'll clean it up myself.
[Long beat. Close-up: Mr. Lawson's eyes soften, almost disbelieving.]
MR. LAWSON: (quietly) In twenty-seven years... you've never once said that to me.
[He slowly puts the checkbook away and touches her cheek.]
MR. LAWSON: Whatever you need. Call me.

[Wide shot: Julian stands in the doorway, unseen. He heard everything.]
[Freeze frame on Julian's face. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 47: Recess

[EXT. MAPLEWOOD ELEMENTARY — PLAYGROUND — DAY 7. Rosie sits on a bench, proudly wearing her penguin-costume hood. Theo plays nearby.]
[Oliver struts over with two friends, holding up his phone with the leaked photo on screen.]
OLIVER: Hey, penguin! Your stepmom's a cheater. Everyone's mom says so.
ROSIE: (small voice) She's not...
OLIVER: She's not even your real mom. She doesn't even like you.
[Oliver yanks the hood. Close-up: the seam rips, and the fluffy penguin hood tears in half.]
[Rosie gasps, tears welling.]
[Whip pan: Theo sprints across the playground and shoves Oliver hard. Oliver stumbles onto the grass.]
THEO: (furious) Don't touch my sister!
[Snap cut: a teacher's whistle blows. Wide shot: every kid on the playground freezes.]
TEACHER: Theo Ashford! Principal's office. Now.

Clip 48: Principal's Office

[INT. PRINCIPAL'S OFFICE — DAY. Principal Hale behind her desk. Julian sits beside Theo and Rosie. Across from them, Mrs. Sinclair, arm around a sulking Oliver.]
MRS. SINCLAIR: Your son shoved mine to the ground. I want him punished.
JULIAN: (calm) Theo. Why did you push him?
THEO: He ripped Rosie's penguin hood. And he said bad things about Mom.
MRS. SINCLAIR: He only said what everyone online is saying. That woman shouldn't be near this school.
[Rosie slides off her chair, clutching the torn hood. Close-up: her chin trembles, but she looks straight at Mrs. Sinclair.]
ROSIE: She's not a bad stepmom. She came to my play. She fixed my hand.
ROSIE: (voice breaking) She's my mommy.
[Long silence. Close-up: Julian's eyes glisten. He puts a hand on Rosie's head.]
[Freeze frame. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 49: Crooked Penguin

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — LIVING ROOM — DAY 7, EVENING. Warm lamplight. Vivian sits on the sofa with a sewing kit, carefully stitching the torn penguin hood. Rosie leans against her arm, watching.]

VIVIAN: It might sit a little crooked when I'm done.
ROSIE: (thinking hard) Then I'll be a crooked penguin.
[Vivian laughs softly. Across the room, Theo pretends to read a book but keeps glancing over.]
VIVIAN: (without looking up) Theo, could you hold the thread for me?
THEO: (sighing loudly) ...Fine. Only because you're doing it wrong.
[He slides onto the sofa and holds the thread. Close-up: three pairs of hands working on the little hood together.]
[Rosie puts the finished hood on. One ear flops sideways.]
ROSIE: (beaming) I love it more now.
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought, lips not moving): The internet says I'm a monster. But right here, on this sofa... I'm just Mom.

Clip 50: Deal on Hold

[INT. JULIAN'S STUDY — NIGHT. Door slightly open. Julian on a video call. On the laptop, a silver-haired man in a sharp suit: MR. HARRINGTON.]
MR. HARRINGTON (ON SCREEN): Julian, I'm putting the resort partnership on hold. It's a family resort, and right now everyone's talking about your wife.
JULIAN: (tight) Those reports aren't the whole story.
MR. HARRINGTON (ON SCREEN): Then fix your family first. We'll talk after.
[The call ends. Julian rubs his temples.]
[Whip pan to the hallway: Vivian stands frozen outside the door.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): In the drama, Julian lost this deal while Vivian was busy getting money for Damon. Now he's losing it because of her past.
[Pan down: crouched behind her, unseen, Theo and Rosie in pajamas, listening. They look at each other.]

Clip 51: The Plan

[INT. TWINS' BEDROOM — NIGHT. A flashlight under a blanket fort. Theo and Rosie whisper.]
ROSIE: Uncle Harrington thinks Mommy's bad. That's why he won't work with Daddy.
THEO: Then we tell him she's not.
ROSIE: How? Grown-ups never listen to kids.
THEO: (determined) They will if we go to his office. Tomorrow.
[Close-up: Theo pulls out a business card from Julian's desk: HARRINGTON TOWER, 88 MERIDIAN AVENUE.]
[EXT. SCHOOL DROP-OFF — DAY 8, MORNING. The Ashford driver waves goodbye. Theo and Rosie walk toward the school gate... then quietly slip behind a delivery van.]
ROSIE: (whispering) Are we in trouble?
THEO: Only if they catch us.

[Wide shot: the twins climb into the back of a city taxi. The door slams. It pulls away.]
[Freeze frame on Rosie's crooked penguin hood in the taxi window. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 52: Harrington Tower

[INT. HARRINGTON TOWER — LOBBY — DAY 8, MORNING. Marble floors, a towering glass atrium. Theo and Rosie, in school uniforms and Rosie's crooked penguin hood, march up to the front desk.]
THEO: (standing tall) We need to see Mr. Harrington. It's very important.
RECEPTIONIST: (smiling politely) Where are your parents, sweetheart?
ROSIE: That's what we're here to talk about.
RECEPTIONIST: (picking up the phone) Security, I have two lost children in the lobby...
[Close-up: Theo grabs Rosie's hand.]
THEO: (whispering) Run.
[Whip pan: the twins dash past the elevators. A guard turns.]
GUARD: Hey! Kids, stop!
[Low angle: the twins dive behind a white-clothed room-service cart and scramble under the cloth. A waiter, unaware, pushes it into the executive elevator.]
[Close-up inside the cart: Rosie's eyes wide in the dark.]
ROSIE: (whispering) It smells like croissants.
THEO: Shh!

Clip 53: Missing

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — FOYER — DAY 8, MORNING. Vivian's phone rings. Close-up on the screen: MAPLEWOOD ELEMENTARY.]
SCHOOL SECRETARY (V.O., phone): Mrs. Ashford, Theo and Rosie aren't in class today. Did you keep them home?
VIVIAN: (frozen) The driver dropped them off an hour ago...
SCHOOL SECRETARY (V.O., phone): They never came through the gate.
[Snap zoom on Vivian's face draining of color.]
[Whip pan: Julian strides out of his study, phone already at his ear.]
JULIAN: (sharp) Lock every gate on the estate. Search the gardens, the garage, the pool house. Everything.
[Wide shot: staff run in every direction, calling the twins' names.]
STAFF: Theo! Rosie!
[Close-up: Vivian grips the staircase railing, shaking.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought, lips not moving): This never happened in the drama. I don't know how this ends.

Clip 54: The Pool

[EXT. ASHFORD MANSION — POOL — DAY. Vivian runs along the garden path, calling.]
VIVIAN: Rosie! Theo!
[She stops dead. Close-up: a small stuffed penguin floating face-down in the deep end of the pool.]
VIVIAN: (screaming) ROSIE!
[Slow motion: Vivian dives into the water fully clothed. Underwater shot: she searches frantically, bubbles rising.]
[She surfaces, gasping, clutching only the soggy toy penguin. No one else in the water.]
[Julian sprints to the edge and pulls her out. She collapses on the tiles, soaked, sobbing.]
VIVIAN: (breaking) This is my fault. Everything I touch goes wrong. If I'd never come into this family...
[Close-up: Julian kneels and grips her shoulders.]
JULIAN: Look at me.
[Freeze frame on Vivian's tear-streaked face. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 55: A Good Mother

[EXT. ASHFORD MANSION — POOLSIDE — DAY 8. Vivian, soaked, kneels on the tiles clutching the dripping toy penguin. Julian kneels in front of her, holding her shoulders.]
JULIAN: Look at me. This is not your fault.
VIVIAN: (sobbing) Every time they trust me, something bad happens to them.
JULIAN: (firm, quiet) I don't know who you were before. Maybe you were cruel. Maybe you made mistakes.
[Close-up: he brushes the wet hair off her face.]
JULIAN: But the woman who just jumped into that pool without thinking... is a good mother.
[Long beat. Vivian stares at him, tears mixing with pool water.]
JULIAN: We'll find them. Together.
[He pulls off his suit jacket and wraps it around her shoulders. His phone buzzes. Close-up on the screen: HARRINGTON.]
[Snap zoom on Julian's face, confused.]
JULIAN: ...Harrington?

Clip 56: Under the Table

[INT. HARRINGTON TOWER — BOARDROOM — DAY. A long glass table. Executives in suits sit around it as Mr. Harrington begins his meeting.]
MR. HARRINGTON: Let's start with the quarterly...
[Under the table: Theo and Rosie crouch between the polished shoes, Rosie's crooked penguin hood bobbing.]
ROSIE: (whispering) My nose itches.
THEO: (whispering) Don't you dare.

[Close-up: Rosie scrunches her face... and sneezes loudly.]
[Wide shot: every executive freezes. Mr. Harrington lifts the tablecloth. Two small faces stare up at him.]
MR. HARRINGTON: ...And who exactly are you two?
THEO: (crawling out, straightening his sweater) Theo and Rosie Ashford. We came to tell you our mom isn't bad.
ROSIE: She bandaged my hand. She saved me at the gala. She came to my play. She sewed my hood. See? It's crooked.
[Close-up: Mr. Harrington stares at the lopsided penguin hood. Slowly, the corner of his mouth lifts.]
MR. HARRINGTON: (picking up his phone) Call Julian Ashford. Tell him to come get his kids.

Clip 57: Families Fight

[The boardroom doors burst open. Vivian runs in, still damp, wrapped in Julian's jacket. Julian follows right behind.]
VIVIAN: Theo! Rosie!
[She drops to her knees and crushes both twins into her arms. Close-up: tears streaming down her face.]
ROSIE: (muffled) Why are you crying? And why are you all wet?
VIVIAN: Because you scared me half to death!
[Mr. Harrington steps forward.]
MR. HARRINGTON: Your children hid in a room-service cart and crawled under my table to defend their mother, Julian. Send me a new proposal. I'll reconsider.
[Close-up: Rosie tugs Julian's sleeve, worried.]
ROSIE: Daddy... are you still sending Mommy away?
JULIAN: (kneeling, looking at Vivian) Who said anything about sending her away? Families fight. That doesn't mean we stop being one.
[Snap zoom on Vivian.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought, lips not moving): In the drama, this is the day he handed her the divorce papers. Instead... he's taking me home.
[Freeze frame on the four of them together. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 58: Untraceable

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — JULIAN'S STUDY — DAY 8, NIGHT. The twins asleep upstairs. Vivian's phone buzzes on the desk. Macro shot: UNKNOWN NUMBER: "Tick tock. $10 million by Sunday, or the next batch goes out. Worse ones."]
JULIAN: (jaw tight) Call the police.
VIVIAN: Every text comes from a different number. Every post is anonymous. If they say they were hacked, we can't prove a thing.

JULIAN: Then what do we do? Pay them?
VIVIAN: (shaking her head) Never.
[Close-up: Vivian stares at the phone, thinking. Slowly, a determined look crosses her face.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought, lips not moving): In the drama, they only won because Vivian was desperate. So... let's make them think I am.
VIVIAN: We give them a show. We make them believe I've lost everything.
JULIAN: (raising an eyebrow) What kind of show?
VIVIAN: The kind where you throw me out.

Clip 59: Acting Class

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — LIVING ROOM — DAY 9, MORNING. Vivian kneels in front of Theo and Rosie. Julian stands behind her, arms crossed.]
VIVIAN: It's pretend. Like the penguin play. We're putting on a show for the bad guys.
ROSIE: (worried) Do I have to cry?
VIVIAN: Only if you want to.
THEO: (serious) Is Dad really going to throw you out?
JULIAN: Only for five minutes.
THEO: ...And then you come back?
VIVIAN: (cupping his face) Then I come back. I promise.
[Close-up: Rosie scrunches her face, practicing an angry glare. It looks adorable, not scary.]
ROSIE: Like this?
JULIAN: (dry) Terrifying.
[Theo stands tall, clenching his fists.]
THEO: I'll be the meanest. That way the bad guys believe it.

Clip 60 & 61 – COMBINED: Thrown Out

[EXT. ASHFORD MANSION — FRONT GATE — DAY 9. A long-lens camera pokes through the hedges across the street. Close-up: a photographer, filming.]
[The front doors fly open. Julian drags Vivian's suitcase down the steps and throws it onto the driveway.]
JULIAN: (shouting, cold) I've read the messages. They're real. Get out of my house, Vivian!
VIVIAN: (crying) Julian, please! At least let me say goodbye to the kids!
[Whip pan: Theo and Rosie in the doorway.]
THEO: (fierce) We don't want you anymore! Go away!
ROSIE: (wobbly voice) ...Bad Mommy. Go away.
[Close-up: Vivian picks up her suitcase and walks out through the gate, shoulders shaking.]
[Hard cut: INT. LUXURY APARTMENT — DAY. Margot watches the footage on her phone, Damon beside her. She smiles slowly.]
MARGOT: She's finished. She'll come crawling to us now.

[Snap cut back to the gate: Rosie, hidden behind the door, whispers to Theo.]
ROSIE: (whispering) Was I good?
THEO: (whispering) You were scary.
[Freeze frame on Rosie's proud grin. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 62: Her Old Room

[EXT. LAWSON ESTATE — DAY 9, AFTERNOON. Vivian stands at the door of a grand old house, suitcase in hand. The door opens. Mr. Lawson, in a cardigan, stares at her.]
MR. LAWSON: Vivian... I saw the video online. Julian really threw you out?
VIVIAN: Can I come in, Dad?
MR. LAWSON: (stepping aside) This is your home. You never need to ask.
[INT. VIVIAN'S CHILDHOOD BEDROOM. Pastel walls, old trophies, a dusty teddy bear on the bed. Nothing has been touched.]
VIVIAN: (quietly) You kept everything the same.
MR. LAWSON: You only ever came home when you needed money. You'd take it and leave. But I wanted you to always have a room to come back to.
[Snap zoom on Vivian, eyes filling with tears.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought, lips not moving): In the drama, the real Vivian never came back. And his heart gave out, alone, in this house.
[She hugs him tightly. Close-up: his surprised face softens.]

Clip 63: The Bait

[INT. LAWSON ESTATE — STUDY — DAY. Vivian and Mr. Lawson sit facing each other.]
VIVIAN: Dad, Julian didn't really throw me out. We staged it. The kids were in on it too.
MR. LAWSON: (stunned) Staged it? Why?
VIVIAN: Margot and Damon are the ones leaking the photos. They use fake accounts, so the police can't prove anything. I need them to admit it out loud.
VIVIAN: Now they think I've lost my husband and my home. They'll expect me to run to you for the ten million.
MR. LAWSON: So the money is bait.
VIVIAN: Yes. I'll tell them I'll only pay in person. And when they confess, I'll be recording.
[Close-up: she types a text to the unknown number: "I have nothing left. I'll pay. Tomorrow, 8 p.m., the Grand Meridian lounge. Come in person."]
[Close-up: Mr. Lawson grips her hand.]
MR. LAWSON: Don't try to be a hero. If anything goes wrong, you walk away.

Clip 64: The Meeting

[INT. GRAND MERIDIAN HOTEL — LOUNGE — DAY 10, NIGHT. Dim gold lights. Vivian sits alone in a booth, a black clutch on the table. Close-up: inside the clutch, her phone screen glows: RECORDING 00:00:12.]
[Damon and Margot walk in and slide into the booth across from her.]
DAMON: (smirking) Look who came crawling.
MARGOT: (sweetly, taking her hand) Oh, Viv. I hate seeing you like this. Just pay him, and this will all go away.
MARGOT: Then I'll help you win Julian back. I promise.
[Snap zoom on Vivian, holding back her disgust.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought): She pushed the real Vivian off that yacht... and now she's pretending to catch her.
VIVIAN: (quietly) If I pay you the ten million, you'll delete the photos? All of them?
DAMON: Every single one. But if you don't pay... the next batch goes online tonight.
[Close-up: the phone in the clutch keeps recording. Freeze frame. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 65: On the Record

[INT. GRAND MERIDIAN HOTEL — LOUNGE — DAY 10, NIGHT. Vivian leans forward, voice steady.]
VIVIAN: So you admit it. You're the ones who posted those photos.
DAMON: (laughing) Of course. And the yacht? Margot pushed you, I jumped in. Best investment I ever made.
VIVIAN: (to Margot) And you told him to leak them?
MARGOT: (rolling her eyes) Someone had to. You stopped paying.
[Close-up: Damon's eyes drop to the open clutch. Macro shot: the phone screen glowing, RECORDING 00:02:47.]
[Snap zoom on Damon's face turning dark.]
DAMON: (low) You're recording us.
[Whip pan: he grabs Vivian's wrist hard and yanks her toward him.]
DAMON: Give me that phone. Now.
VIVIAN: (struggling) Let go of me!
[Freeze frame on Damon's hand around her wrist. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 66: Three Punches

[Whip pan: a hand clamps onto Damon's shoulder and spins him around. Julian.]
JULIAN: (ice-cold) She told you to let go.
[Slow motion: Julian punches Damon across the jaw. Damon stumbles back into the booth.]
JULIAN: That's for my wife.
[Damon lunges, and Julian punches him again.]
JULIAN: That's for my kids.

[One more punch. Damon crashes to the floor.]
JULIAN: And that one's for me.
[Wide shot: guests gasp. Margot shrinks into the booth, white as paper.]
[Close-up: Julian pulls Vivian behind him, checking her wrist.]
JULIAN: (softly) Are you hurt?
VIVIAN: (shaking her head, breathless) You were supposed to stay outside.
JULIAN: I was outside. Then he touched you.
[The lounge doors burst open. Police officers stride in.]

Clip 67: Arrested

[Two officers haul Damon to his feet and snap handcuffs on him. A third officer turns to Margot.]
OFFICER: Margot Pierce, you're under arrest for blackmail and extortion.
MARGOT: (panicking) Wait! It was all Damon! He made me do it!
DAMON: (spitting blood) You liar! You planned all of it. The photos, the texts, everything!
[Close-up: Vivian holds up her phone.]
VIVIAN: You can both tell the judge. It's all on here.
[Margot twists toward Vivian as the officers drag her away.]
MARGOT: (desperate) Viv, please! We've been friends for ten years!
VIVIAN: (calm) No, Margot. You were never my friend.
[Wide shot: both are marched out in handcuffs as phones film them.]
[Close-up: Julian takes Vivian's hand and gently brushes his thumb over her bruised wrist.]
JULIAN: Show's over, Mrs. Ashford. Let's go home.
[Freeze frame on Vivian's teary smile. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]

Clip 68: Welcome Home

[INT. ASHFORD MANSION — FOYER — DAY 10, NIGHT. The front door opens. Julian and Vivian step inside. Theo and Rosie, in pajamas, have been waiting on the stairs.]
ROSIE: (jumping up) Mommy! Did you catch the bad guys?
VIVIAN: (kneeling, arms open) We caught them. Aunt Margot and Damon can't hurt us anymore.
[The twins crash into her arms.]
THEO: (muffled) So the photos stop now?
VIVIAN: They stop now.
[Close-up: Rosie pulls back, suddenly serious.]
ROSIE: But what if Daddy really throws you out one day?
VIVIAN: (smiling) Then I'll take you two with me.
THEO: (thinking) We should take Dad too. He'll get scared all alone in this big house.
[Close-up: Julian, leaning against the doorframe, raises an eyebrow.]
JULIAN: Thank you for remembering me, Theo.

[Rosie tugs Julian’s hand and puts it on Vivian’s shoulder.]
ROSIE: Daddy, you have to make up with Mommy. She caught bad guys today.

Clip 69: The Confession

[EXT. ASHFORD MANSION — BALCONY — NIGHT. City lights below. The twins are asleep. Vivian stands at the railing, wrapped in a shawl. Julian steps out beside her.]
JULIAN: You promised them you wouldn’t leave.
VIVIAN: You heard that?
JULIAN: Every word.
[Long beat. Close-up: Vivian takes a deep breath.]
VIVIAN: Julian... there’s something you need to know. I’m not the woman you married.
VIVIAN: I don’t remember her life. I don’t remember your wedding, or those photos, or Damon. One morning I just... woke up as her.
[Snap zoom on Julian. Silence.]
VIVIAN (V.O., inner thought, lips not moving): He’s going to think I’m crazy.
[Close-up: Julian looks at her for a long moment, then speaks softly.]
JULIAN: I know you’re not her. She never once looked at my children the way you do.
JULIAN: The woman I married left. You’re the one who stayed.

Clip 70: Nice to Meet You

[Julian turns to face her fully, holding out his hand like it’s their first meeting.]
JULIAN: Then let’s start over. I’m Julian Ashford.
[Close-up: Vivian looks at his hand, eyes glistening. She takes it.]
VIVIAN: (whispering) ...Emma.
JULIAN: (softly) Emma?
VIVIAN: That’s my real name. I was a kindergarten teacher. I ate instant noodles for dinner. And somehow... I ended up here.
[Julian smiles, a real smile, the first one we’ve seen.]
JULIAN: Who’s Emma?
VIVIAN: (laughing through tears) Someone who’s staying.
[Slow push in: Julian pulls her close and kisses her under the night sky.]
[Whip pan up to a window: Rosie and Theo peeking out, grinning. Rosie mouths “yes!”]
[Freeze frame on the kiss. Text: TO BE CONTINUED]